

REFORMING RESEARCH ASSESSMENT

EUA-CDE CoARA Action Plan

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EUA Council for Doctoral Education (EUA-CDE)

Rue du Rhône 114
Case postale 3174
1211 Geneva 3, Switzerland
+41 22 552 02 96

eua-cde.org · info@eua-cde.org

Context

The European University Association (EUA) has made reforming research assessment and academic careers one of its strategic objectives, as outlined in its vision for universities by 2030 – [Universities without walls](#). In the last years, EUA has widely engaged in promoting this reform by participating in a significant initiative aimed at advancing a more efficient, inclusive and higher quality research system - the [Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment](#). EUA, alongside Science Europe, the European Commission and Dr Karen Stroobants (in her personal capacity as researcher) has been instrumental in the drafting process of the agreement. EUA is also one of the initiators of the [Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment](#) (CoARA).

Reflecting EUA's position on this topic, research assessment reform is also a priority for action of the EUA Council for Doctoral Education (EUA-CDE) as defined in its [vision for the future of doctoral education in Europe](#). This vision mentions the necessity for 'doctoral schools to prepare doctoral candidates for a world where research assessment is not uniquely focused on quantitative, publication-based indicators such as the journal impact factor' and emphasizes the importance of ensuring that the voice of doctoral candidates is integral to this reform process.

EUA-CDE's support to enhancing assessment practices took form with the endorsement of the Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment in November 2022 and its consequent membership of the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) at the end of 2022. As such, the topic of research assessment has become central for many EUA-CDE activities in recent years.

Accordingly, EUA-CDE has developed this action plan that details its past, ongoing and forthcoming actions to foster a research environment where diverse contributions are equally recognised and valued. Additionally, EUA has drafted an overarching [action plan](#) that highlights the Association's policy and primary activities in support of the reform.

Past EUA-CDE activities (2019-2024)

CoARA commitment 5 (commit resources to reforming research assessment)

- Actively participated in the CoARA Working Group on 'Reforming Academic Career Assessment (ACA)' to share insights and disseminate the main outcomes of this WG. This initiative co-chaired by EUA and the Young Academy of Europe aims to define objectives to reform ACA and develop a flexible toolbox for implementation.
- Actively participated and contributed to the activities of the CoARA Working Group on 'Early-and-mid-Career Researchers (EMCRs)–Assessment and Research Culture', focused on the impact of different assessment procedures on EMCRCs' career trajectories.

CoARA commitment 7 (raise awareness of research assessment reform) and CoARA commitment 8 (exchange practices and experiences)

- Engaged in reflections on institutional approaches to research assessment during dedicated sessions at EUA-CDE yearly events such as the 2020 [Thematic Workshop](#) and the past two Annual Meetings.
- Provided information to members in relation to the development of more responsible and sustainable evaluation practices and kept them informed about the latest advancements in this field.

CoARA commitment 9 (communicate progress on adherence to the principles)

- Participated in discussions and delivered speeches at several doctoral education conferences about advancing the current research assessment system e.g. 2022 Finnish [national doctoral education Day](#), OsloMet research [Conference](#), CRUE [Debate](#) on the future of Doctoral Education, 4th [Gago Conference](#) on European Science Policy, [Research Futures](#) event, 2023 Centre for Advanced Academic Studies – Dubrovnik [Conference](#), 2024 Ivane Javakhishvili Tbilisi State University Summer School: Shaping the Future — Education, Innovation and Research Excellence.
- Contributed to the debate by authoring articles for higher education news outlets e.g. piece for [Universitas](#), [article](#) on EUA-CDE doctoral debate blog, article in [University World News](#), [post](#) on Eurodoc website, [opinion](#) in University World News and [article](#) in News Tank Academic.
- Provided feedback to the policy developments within the ERA Forum concerning the reform of research assessment.

Planned actions: 2024 and beyond

CoARA commitment 5 (commit resources to reforming research assessment)

- Continue to actively participate in the CoARA Working Group on 'Reforming Academic Career Assessment (ACA)' to share insights and disseminate the main outcomes of this WG.
- Continue to actively participate and contribute to the activities of the CoARA Working Group on 'Early-and-mid-Career Researchers (EMCRs)–Assessment and Research Culture'.
- Support EUA's efforts to reform academic careers through the active participation of an EUA-CDE Steering Committee member in EUA's task-and-finish group on academic careers. This group will develop a vision paper on the impact of a holistic approach to academic careers. Our involvement will ensure that the perspectives of our doctoral education community are reflected in this broader discussion.

CoARA commitment 7 (raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent guidance) & CoARA commitment 8 (exchange practices and experiences)

- Raise awareness within the doctoral education community about responsible research assessment practices and organise membership activities to enhance this effort.
- Encourage EUA-CDE members to review research assessment criteria and processes and exchange best practices and experiences related to the development of research assessment approaches.

- Engage in reflections on institutional approaches to research assessment during dedicated sessions at EUA-CDE yearly events such as the 2025 Annual Meeting.
- Empower EUA-CDE members to actively support both supervisors and doctoral candidates in navigating the complex world of research assessment, while ensuring that doctoral candidates' perspectives can shape future strategies and policies. Our commitment will also be reinforced through the delivery of presentations on CoARA-related objectives at relevant European conferences.
- Advocate for assessment practices that are responsible, transparent and sustainable.

CoARA commitment 9 (communicate progress on adherence to the principles)

- Make use of our communication channels (website, social media platforms, periodic newsletter etc.) to provide information about relevant developments in the field and novel research assessment practices implemented at EUA-CDE member universities.
- Incorporate EUA-CDE members' progress to ensure that our work remains relevant and reflective of cutting-edge developments within our community.
- Maintain an ongoing dialogue with all relevant stakeholders regarding the research assessment reform process.

The EUA Council for Doctoral Education (EUA-CDE) was launched in 2008 at the initiative of the European University Association, responding to a growing interest in doctoral education and research training in Europe. An integral part of the European University Association, it is now the largest European network in this field, covering more than 280 universities and institutions working on issues related to doctoral education and research training in 39 countries.

Since its creation, EUA-CDE has been leading the transformation and strengthening of doctoral education in Europe. Building on the outcomes of EUA's work on doctoral programmes and research careers, EUA-CDE has been the driving force behind the implementation of the Salzburg Principles and Recommendations and the promotion of doctoral education as the main intersection between the European higher education and research.

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